use every instrument of influence at their command to advance their interests.

In the past, such tools were visualized as a spectrum, with application of force as one extreme and the power of example as the other. There were practical options that emerged in between, and even their use was tempered by shared interests and common restraint. Perhaps these have not always worked. Whether it was the selective use of force or the application of sanctions, those who had an edge have often chosen to use it. But as a whole, the belief in globalization tended to be a discouragement to adventurism. However, as stakes rose and contradictions sharpened, major powers have displayed the mentality of ‘war by other means’. What characterizes our times is a willingness to be far more muscular and unabashed in using the toolbox of influence and capability. That it also contains more tools only encourages the practice further. In fact, we are seeing that approach develop to a point of exploiting many aspects of our globalized life and its activities.

Trade was always political, but is much more so today. Market shares are being openly leveraged for political messaging, whether by buyers or sellers. Monopolies, whether of goods or technology, are being even more ruthlessly exploited. Finance is equally potent, be it the power of currencies or the desperation of debt. Connectivity has acquired a growing connotation of linkage and dependency, assisted by lack of transparency and market viability. Technology, in fact, takes it to a new level because it can be harnessed even more intrusively. As for data, this offers a unique insight into the very mindset of societies. Even the flow of tourism, when it is directed, becomes a card in the influence game. All of these are ‘normal’ facets of interdependence, often entered into without adequate thought or due diligence.

But competitive politics is not just an exercise in leveraging or coercion; it is equally one of inducements. As a result, projects, activities and interactions all represent avenues to promote and exercise influence. We see that across a broad swath ranging from education and business to media and entertainment. That interpenetration is now so natural and extensive makes these possibilities that much easier.

Encouraging acquiescence or engineering change is as old as politics. The modern nation-state provides the analytical construct for this to be played out as international relations. In its most extreme form, these